

“I Am Not an Activist”: The Digital Authoritarian Bargain in Kazakhstan

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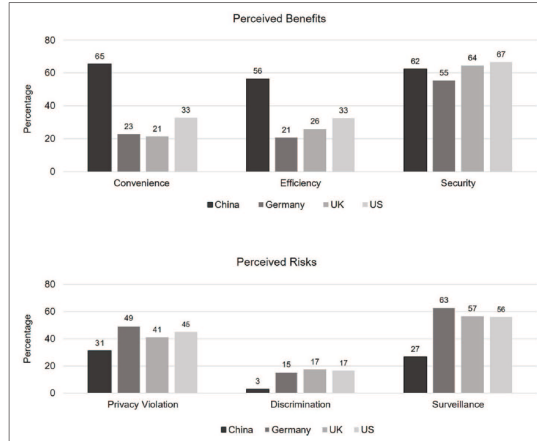
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The puzzle: benefits outweigh risks in the public eye

(Kostka, Steinacker & Meckel 2021)



Perceived consequences of FRT by country (N = 6099).

Why do citizens back a technology in a state without the institutions that would prevent it from being turned against them?

Why Chinese citizens approve: a system of narratives

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- very high approval for all sorts of digital and automated state services (Kostka 2019; Kostka, Steinacker & Meckel 2021; Kostka & Antoine 2019; Li & Kostka; 2022 Kostka 2023)
- Asked about cameras, WeChat and social credit, participants kept turning to morality, rules and punishment (Ollier-Malaterre 2024).
- the lack of **“moral quality” of fellow citizens**, which makes rules and punishment necessary; the century of national humiliations and the civilisational dream; privacy as the hiding of shameful behaviour, so that wanting privacy is suspect
- technology as a **magic bullet**
- **privacy** is can be socially undesirable
- **dissociation tactics** used by 88% regardless of their view of surveillance: brushing it aside (“no risk”), othering the targets (“I am a small potato, a good person”), wearing blinders (“so far it has not harmed me”), fatalism (“I can only accept it”)

Kazakhstan as a natural laboratory

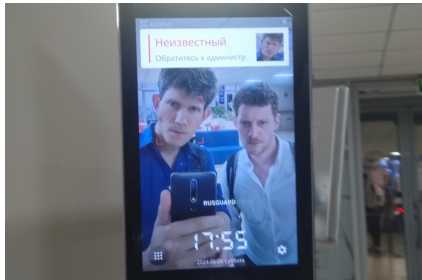
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Kaspi: 14.6 million active payment users in a country of 20 million, 77 transactions per user and month (Kaspi.kz FY 2025 results). Over 7 million people, about half of all adults, have obtained public services through the app, including the registration of a third of all vehicles (CSIS 2024)

- An oil-rich state with the money and the foreign partners to automate (Daminov 2026)
- **FRT camera network** developed with Chinese partners
- Providers must **store user data**, SIM cards are sold against ID, traffic is inspected at the backbone, and the state has shopped for spyware that breaks into phones
- a full **internet shutdown** during the January 2022 unrest, website blocks tripled in eight years
- Much of this is run by private firms. **Social-media monitoring, bot networks** and the cameras are contracted out

- Citizens judge a governance arrangement by what it delivers and by how it operates.
- Outcome favorability + procedural considerations (Schmidt 2013; Esaiasson et al. 2019; Doherty & Wolak 2012; Karpa & Gritsenko 2026)
- In autocracies, digital governance is the latest medium through which the state delivers its side, and the same infrastructure carries the service and the capacity for political control (Desai 2009; Guriev & Treisman 2020)
- Our vignette mirrors this bargain for a single instrument: the **outcome framings** vary its benefit, the **repression cue** discloses its cost

- **Cost:** the same infrastructure lets the state identify and repress opposition before it mobilizes (Feldstein 2021; Dragu & Lupu 2021; Maerz 2026; Daminov 2026). In Russia, disclosing this cost 24 percentage points of approval (Karpa & Rochlitz 2025)

H1. *Disclosing that the system can be used to restrict civil liberties lowers support.*

- **Benefit:** citizens acquiesce as long as the regime is competent and delivers (Desai 2009; Guriev & Treisman 2020). Addressing corruption in particular buys autocrats legitimacy and popularity (Carothers 2022; Kang & Zhu 2021; Tsai, Trinh & Liu 2022)

H2. *Framing the system as delivering a valued outcome raises support.*

- Original online survey in Kazakhstan, March 2025, fielded by NAC Analytica, pre-registered before fielding
- Recruited via Instagram, quota sampling on region, age and gender. $N = 3,124$ complete observations
- Covariates: gender, age, financial situation, education, ethnicity, religion and religiosity, language use, media exposure, social trust, trust in government
- Trust in government and the perceived seriousness of each of the five problems are measured **before** the vignette
- Outcome: approval of algorithmic governance, 1–4 Likert scale. Linear model with all cell means, HC0 standard errors, covariate-adjusted where stated

Framing	No repression cue	Repression cue	Total
Control	257	277	534
Corruption	286	242	528
Islamic fundamentalism	251	249	500
Security	260	273	533
Trust	243	258	501
Public health	261	267	528
Total	1,558	1,566	3,124

- Five outcome framings (less corruption, less Islamic fundamentalism, more public security, more social trust, better public health) plus a control that promises no specific outcome, crossed with a binary repression cue: 12 arms
- Each outcome addresses a documented problem in Kazakhstan for which digital governance is offered as a remedy, so we treat them as separate treatments rather than pooling them
- The repression cue states that the system could be used to suppress political opposition. Covariates are balanced across arms

Example vignette: corruption framing with repression cue

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In many countries, new technologies have been implemented that use data and computing to improve specific government services. These technologies enhance the efficiency of administrative and public services. Next, we will ask you to evaluate new technologies that have been proposed for implementation in our country.

[one of 5 gaps or control]

One of the problems that new technologies aim to address is **corruption in government administration** in our country. New technologies will reduce corruption in state bureaucracy. Documents and applications can be submitted online without delays and without opportunities for bribery.

[repression or control]

These technologies can also be used to restrict civil liberties. For example, they could be employed to target political protesters or journalists.

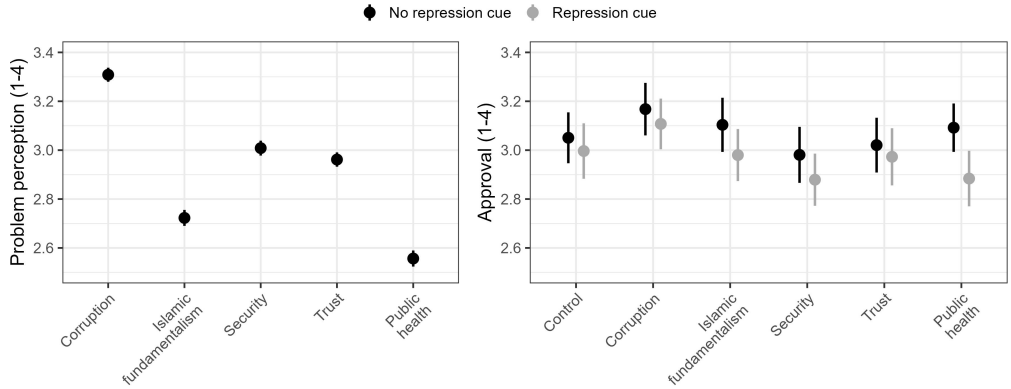
The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

To what extent do you approve the implementation of these technologies in our country? Approve / Somewhat approve / Somewhat disapprove / Disapprove.

Grey: shared by all twelve arms. Bold: the repression cue, present in six arms. The control arm has no framing sentences. All 30 think-aloud respondents read this cell. all framings

- Designed after the experimental results were in, to follow up one of them: in Almaty and Astana, adding the repression cue to the corruption framing raises rather than lowers approval
- All 30 respondents read the **corruption vignette with the repression cue** and verbalized their thoughts while reading and forming a judgment (Ericsson & Simon 1993)
- Quota from the survey sample: 10 Astana, 10 Almaty, 10 other regions, balanced on survey language, gender, age group and religion. Every protocol links to the respondent's pre-treatment survey answers
- Model-testing case selection in the sense of nested analysis (Lieberman 2005). Coded blind to residence against a codebook fixed before coding

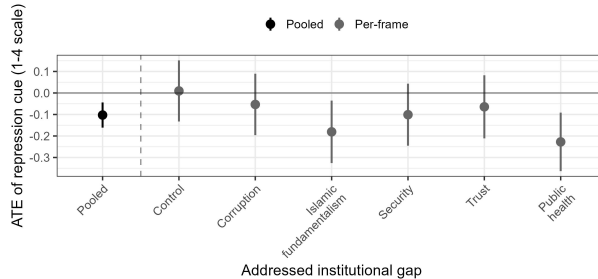
Perceived problems and approval by cell



H1: the repression penalty

specifications

interflex



- Pooled repression ATE: -5.7 percentage points (78.1% → 72.5%), -0.10 on the 1-4 scale ($p < 0.001$). Stable across specifications (-5.6 unadjusted, -6.1 with the five problem ratings held constant). Russia: -24 points (Karpa & Rochlitz 2025)

H1 confirmed

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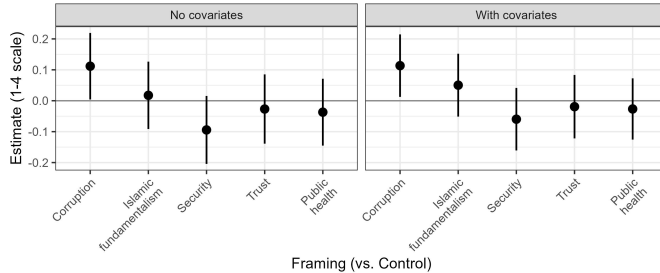
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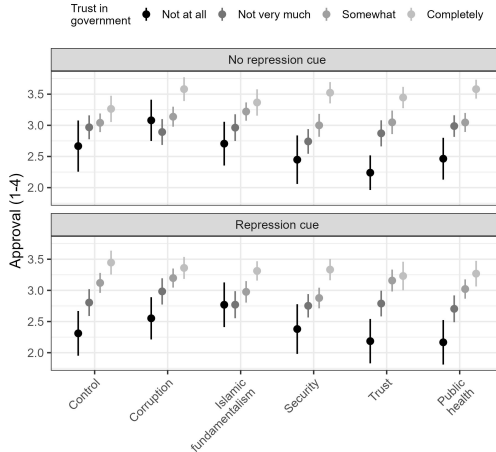
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H2: only corruption raises support saliency

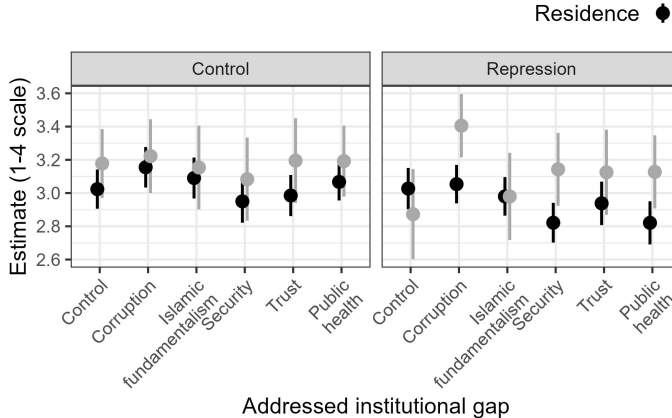


- Pooled across arms, only the corruption framing raises approval (+0.11, $p = 0.03$). Public health, social trust, security and Islamic fundamentalism do not. Ordered logit: same pattern
- Islamic fundamentalism: +0.15 ($p = 0.045$) without the cue, reversed sign with it, zero pooled
- Two of the three problems rated most pressing, social trust and public security, leave approval unchanged. **H2 confirmed for corruption, rejected for the other four**

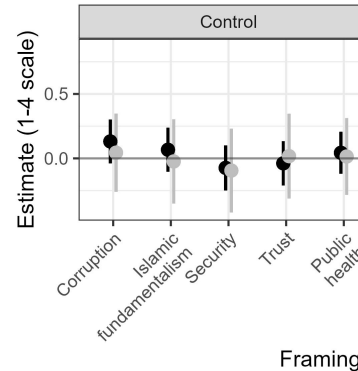


- Respondents recognize the five problems at different rates (88% to 54%) but approve of the system at nearly the same rate whichever problem it promises to solve
- A respondent's own rating of a problem does not change how much its promise moves them, for corruption as for the other four ($p > 0.24$ throughout)
- Trust in government, measured before the vignette: +0.24 per scale point ($p < 0.001$), +0.72 across its range, six times the corruption framing. It moderates neither the framings nor the cue ($p = 0.15-0.54$)

(a) Predictions



(b) CATE comparisons



Capital residents are younger, better educated, more often in the private sector, more exposed to Western media, but do not trust the government more. Three-way interactions with each characteristic leave the residence coefficient unchanged

- **8 of 30** cannot connect public administration and repression. They read the sentence about protesters and journalists, say they do not understand it or ask what it has to do with the technology, and return to their verdict on the service half
- **4** read the persecution of protesters and journalists as ordinary order-keeping that needs no justification
- Of the **24 approvers**, 5 read the cue as a threat to people like themselves and approve nonetheless. The other 19 do not process it, read it as a cost that falls on other people, as legitimate control, or as a price worth paying. Only 2 rewrite it
- 4 state explicitly that they are not the kind of person the cue is about

“Persecution for political activists and journalists. That part I don’t quite understand.” (ID8369)

“Nothing like that has happened to me personally, because I am neither a journalist nor an activist.” (ID14883)

- **15 of 30** articulate the anti-corruption mechanism unprompted, removing the face-to-face contact in which a bribe changes hands. Several describe it as something e-government already delivers
- **17** believe it would work, **7** doubt it: new forms of corruption, portals so complicated that people pay helpers. The doubt does not decide the verdict
- **7** report own or proximate experience of corruption; for the other 23 it is hearsay or the word in the vignette

“The person submitting the request and the person receiving it. . . they don’t directly interact with each other. . . so there’s no opportunity to give a bribe.”
(ID11243)

“They do not solve this problem. New forms of corruption have emerged. . . the portals have been complicated to such an extent that people have to turn to helpers and pay them.” (ID1506)

- **29 of 30** invoke an existing digital service unprompted (eGov 18, Kaspi 14, Public Service Centers 13), at the generic opening shared by all framings, before any problem is named. **17** read the proposal as already in place. Same rates in the capitals and elsewhere
- Service experience and regime evaluation stay apart: **14** keep the two separate, 9 cross in one direction, 6 in both.
- failures of the system are used to blame the government, functioning systems are not used to praise the government.

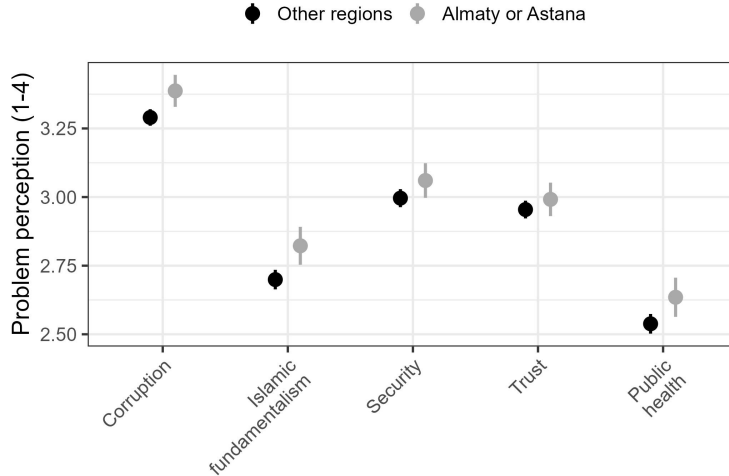
"This probably reminds me of something like our E-gov... We already have this data, like, through the phone we can easily get some services we need." (ID833)

"Entire databases were disclosed... And our government does this." (ID827)

- Capitals: **11 of 20** either do not process the cue (7) or read it as legitimate control (4). Other regions: 1 of 10 fails to process it, none reads it as legitimate
- Other regions: 8 of 10 read the cue as a threat, 5 to people like themselves, 3 to others
- Verdict formed before the cue is reached: 9 of 20 in the capitals, 2 of 10 elsewhere
- Corruption experience, the anti-corruption mechanism and the e-government anchor are distributed alike across the groups

"I didn't understand how it restricts freedoms... to prevent that from happening again, I think it's right." (ID5766, Astana)

"If I were to go out to a rally now, I'd be taken away immediately... then I don't need it at all." (ID1504, other region)



Same same but different?

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China (Ollier-Malaterre 2024)	Kazakhstan, our data
Technology as convenience, magic bullet, normalised	Technology as convenience, already in place: nearly all anchor on e-government
Othering the targets ("small potato", "good person")	Othering the targets ("I am not an activist", activists, journalists, criminals)
Blinders ("so far it has not harmed me")	Blinders ("nothing like that has happened to me")
Government as protector	—
Moral quality: rules and punishment for fellow citizens	Absent
National humiliation, civilisational dream	Some pride; Europe as the benchmark to catch up with
Privacy as hiding shameful behaviour	Absent; privacy as data-leak risk, and the state is the leak

Thank you!

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Appendix

Table 1: Treatment Wording by Framing and Repression Cue

Framing	No repression cue	Repression cue
	<i>Introduction shown to all respondents:</i> In many countries, new technologies have been implemented that use data and computing to improve specific government services. These technologies enhance the efficiency of administrative and public services. Next, we will ask you to evaluate new technologies that have been proposed for implementation in our country.	
Corruption	One of the problems that new technologies aim to address is corruption in government administration in our country. New technologies will reduce corruption in state bureaucracy. Documents and applications can be submitted online without delays and without opportunities for bribery. The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.	Same as left, plus: These technologies can also be used to restrict civil liberties. For example, they could be employed to target political protesters or journalists. The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

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Islamic fun-
damentalism

One of the problems that new technologies aim to address is the rise of extreme religious beliefs in our country. New technologies will facilitate the identification of individuals spreading radical religious views. The collected data will be used to detect individuals who are likely to become radicals. The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

Same as left, plus repression cue.

Security

One of the problems that new technologies aim to address is the lack of security in our country. New technologies will enable more effective identification and apprehension of criminals before they commit a crime. The collected data will be used to detect individuals who are highly likely to commit crimes in the future. The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

Same as left, plus repression cue.

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Trust

One of the problems that new technologies aim to address is the lack of trust in our country. New technologies will make relationships between people more trustworthy and efficient, particularly in business interactions. The collected data will be used to calculate a unique trust rating based on past behavior. The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

Same as left, plus repression cue.

Public health

One of the problems that new technologies aim to address is the spread of infectious diseases in our country. The collected data will be used to identify infected citizens in order to limit the spread of the disease. The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

Same as left, plus repression cue.

Control

The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.

Same as left, plus repression cue.

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Outcome question (all respondents): To what extent do you approve the implementation of these technologies in our country? Approve / Somewhat approve / Somewhat disapprove / Disapprove.

The survey was administered in Russian and Kazakh; the wording above is the English version of the questionnaire. In the repression-cue conditions, the repression sentences were inserted before the closing sentence “The government of Kazakhstan plans to implement these new technologies.”

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Repression cue	-0.056*** (0.015)	-0.054*** (0.015)	-0.057*** (0.015)	-0.061*** (0.014)
Corruption	-	0.049 (0.025)	0.050* (0.024)	0.050* (0.024)
Islamic fundamentalism	-	0.016 (0.026)	0.028 (0.025)	0.031 (0.025)
Security	-	-0.040 (0.027)	-0.027 (0.025)	-0.019 (0.025)
Trust	-	-0.020 (0.027)	-0.017 (0.025)	-0.019 (0.025)
Public health	-	-0.009 (0.027)	-0.004 (0.025)	-0.006 (0.025)
Sociodemographic & media controls	No	No	Yes	Yes
Institutional gap perceptions	No	No	No	Yes
Num. Obs.	3,124	3,124	3,124	3,124
R ²	0.004	0.009	0.126	0.148

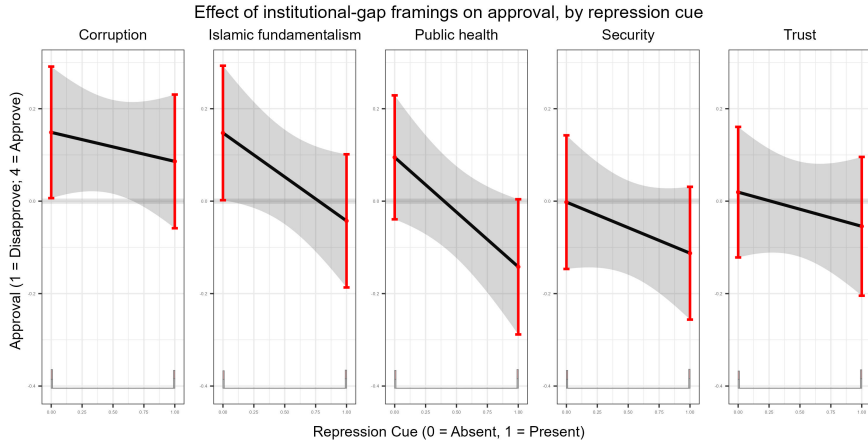
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Outcome: dichotomized approval (1 = somewhat/strongly approve, 0 = somewhat/strongly disapprove). Framing coefficients are relative to the no-justification Control condition. Robust (HCO) standard errors in parentheses. Column (3) controls: age group, gender, financial situation, higher education, ethnicity, religious affiliation and religiosity, language used at home / with peers / for news, exposure to Russian, Kazakh, Western, and other media, social trust, and trust in government. Column (4) adds the five institutional-gap perception items (corruption, Islamic fundamentalism, security, trust, public health).

	Corruption	Islamic fund.	Security	Trust	Public health
Framing (vs. Control)	−0.173 (0.252)	0.011 (0.178)	−0.007 (0.212)	−0.044 (0.213)	0.098 (0.159)
Own gap salience (1–4)	0.165** (0.052)	0.157*** (0.043)	0.143** (0.048)	0.131** (0.047)	0.034 (0.043)
Framing × own salience	0.086 (0.074)	0.017 (0.061)	−0.016 (0.069)	0.009 (0.069)	−0.047 (0.058)
Repression cue	−0.042 (0.051)	−0.072 (0.051)	−0.056 (0.051)	−0.053 (0.051)	−0.119* (0.050)
Sociodemographic & media controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Num. Obs.	1,062	1,034	1,067	1,035	1,062
R ²	0.183	0.184	0.197	0.212	0.189

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Outcome: approval on the 1–4 Likert scale. Each column restricts the sample to the Control arm and the named framing arm (pooled across repression conditions) and interacts the framing indicator with the respondent's pre-treatment agreement that the corresponding problem exists in Kazakhstan (Table 2). Robust (HC0) standard errors in parentheses. Controls: age group, gender, financial situation, higher education, ethnicity, religious affiliation and religiosity, language used at home / with peers / for news, exposure to Russian, Kazakh, Western, and other media, social trust, and trust in government.

	Corruption	Islamic fund.	Security	Trust	Public health	Repression
Framing (vs. Control)	0.211 (0.177)	0.213 (0.174)	-0.184 (0.179)	-0.240 (0.168)	-0.162 (0.175)	-
Trust in government (1-4)	0.224*** (0.045)	0.212*** (0.046)	0.210*** (0.045)	0.199*** (0.045)	0.216*** (0.046)	0.225*** (0.025)
Framing × trust	-0.036 (0.058)	-0.061 (0.058)	0.046 (0.059)	0.081 (0.056)	0.051 (0.058)	-
Repression cue	-0.021 (0.052)	-0.067 (0.052)	-0.060 (0.052)	-0.036 (0.051)	-0.121* (0.050)	-0.186 (0.100)
Repression × trust	-	-	-	-	-	0.031 (0.033)
Framing dummies	-	-	-	-	-	Yes
Sociodemographic & media controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Num. Obs.	1,062	1,034	1,067	1,035	1,062	3,124
R ²	0.153	0.158	0.184	0.199	0.189	0.161

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Outcome: approval on the 1-4 Likert scale. Columns (1)-(5) restrict the sample to the Control arm and the named framing arm (pooled across repression conditions); column (6) uses the full sample and interacts the repression cue with trust in government. Robust (HCO) standard errors in parentheses. Controls: age group, gender, financial situation, higher education, ethnicity, religious affiliation and religiosity, language used at home / with peers / for news, exposure to Russian, Kazakh, Western, and other media, social trust.



Binning estimator (Hainmueller, Mummolo & Xu 2019): treatment effects across moderator values without a linear-interaction assumption.
The pattern matches the per-frame contrasts in the main text.

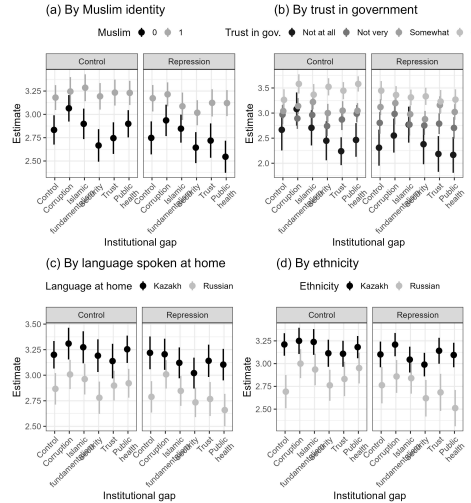


Table 2: Survey Items: Question Wording and Scales

Variable	Wording	Scale
<i>Outcome</i>		
Approval of algorithmic governance	To what extent do you approve the implementation of these technologies in our country? (asked after the treatment vignette, Table 1)	Likert scale (1 = Disapprove, 2 = Somewhat disapprove, 3 = Somewhat approve, 4 = Approve); dichotomized version: 1 if 3 or 4
<i>Sociodemographics</i>		
Age	Please indicate your age	Open numeric field (integer, range 18–100); models use five age groups (18–29, 30–39, 40–49, 50–59, 60+)
Female	Please indicate your gender	0 = Male, 1 = Female
Urban	In which region do you primarily reside?	1 if Astana or Almaty, 0 otherwise (17 regions and 3 cities of republican significance offered)

Survey items and summary statistics

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Financial situa-
tion

How would you describe your fam-
ily's financial situation?

Five ordered categories (1 =
Not enough money for food, 5
= No financial difficulties); en-
tered as categorical

Education level

What is your highest level of edu-
cation?

Seven ordered categories (1
= No formal education, 7 =
Completed higher education);
models use an indicator for
complete or incomplete higher
education

Ethnicity

What is your ethnicity?

Kazakh, Russian, Other
Islam, Orthodox Christian-
ity, Catholicism or Protes-
tantism, Judaism, Buddhism,
Hinduism, Other, Not reli-
gious; "Muslim" indicator = 1
if Islam

Religious affilia-
tion

Which religious affiliation do you
identify with?

Religious prac-
tice frequency

How often do you engage in reli-
gious or prayer practices? (asked
only of respondents with a religious
affiliation)

Five ordered categories
(Never, At least once a year,
At least once a month, At
least once a week, Every day);
models use an indicator for at
least weekly practice

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Language and media

Language used at home	What language do you use most frequently at home?	Kazakh, Russian, English, Turkish, Other
Language used with peers	What language do you use most frequently at work, school, or with friends?	Same as above
Language used for news	What language do you most frequently use to access, search for, or read news about political or economic events?	Same as above, plus "Not interested in news"
Russian media exposure	From which sources do you receive news about political or economic events? (up to four sources) What are the countries of origin of the channels, groups, or blogs you frequently visit?	Count of selected sources originating in Russia (0–4)
Kazakh media exposure	Same as above	Count of selected sources originating in Kazakhstan (0–4)
Western media exposure	Same as above	Count of selected sources originating in Western countries, e.g. EU or USA (0–4)

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Other media exposure

Same as above

Count of selected sources originating in other countries (0–8; multiple countries per source possible)

Attitudes

General social trust

To what extent do you think most people can be trusted?

Likert scale (1 = Cannot be trusted at all, 4 = Can be fully trusted)

Trust in government

How much do you trust the government of Kazakhstan?

Likert scale (1 = Do not trust at all, 4 = Completely trust)

Gap perception: corruption

There is a problem with corruption in government administration in Kazakhstan.

Likert scale (1 = Disagree, 4 = Agree)

Gap perception: Islamic fundamentalism

There is a problem with the rise of extreme religious beliefs in Kazakhstan.

Same as above

Gap perception: security

There is a problem with insufficient security and crime in Kazakhstan.

Same as above

Gap perception: trust in society

There is a problem with a lack of trust among citizens in Kazakhstan.

Same as above

Gap perception: public health

There is a problem with the spread of infectious diseases in Kazakhstan.

Same as above

All items except the outcome were asked before the experimental vignette. Summary statistics in Table 3.

Table 3: Summary Statistics

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
<i>Outcome</i>					
Approval of algorithmic governance (1–4)	3,124	3.02	0.90	1	4
Approval, dichotomized (1 = approve)	3,124	0.753	0.431	0	1
<i>Sociodemographics</i>					
Age (years)	3,124	42.1	14.4	18	82
Age group (0 = 18–29, 1 = 30–39, 2 = 40–49, 3 = 50–59, 4 = 60+)	3,124	1.76	1.35	0	4
Female	3,124	0.525	0.499	0	1
Urban (Almaty or Astana)	3,124	0.191	0.393	0	1
Financial situation					
Not enough money for food	3,124	0.070	0.255	0	1
Enough for food, not for clothing	3,124	0.171	0.376	0	1
Enough for food and clothing, durables difficult	3,124	0.469	0.499	0	1
Enough for everything but a car or apartment	3,124	0.259	0.438	0	1
No financial difficulties	3,124	0.031	0.174	0	1
Education level					
No formal education	3,124	0.004	0.062	0	1
Secondary (incomplete)	3,124	0.039	0.195	0	1
Secondary (complete)	3,124	0.206	0.405	0	1
Vocational (incomplete)	3,124	0.091	0.288	0	1
Vocational (complete)	3,124	0.255	0.436	0	1
Higher (incomplete)	3,124	0.076	0.265	0	1
Higher (complete)	3,124	0.328	0.469	0	1
Higher education (complete or incomplete)	3,124	0.404	0.491	0	1
Ethnicity					
Kazakh	3,124	0.649	0.477	0	1
Russian	3,124	0.309	0.462	0	1
Other	3,124	0.042	0.200	0	1

Survey items and summary statistics

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Religious affiliation					
Islam	3,124	0.589	0.492	0	1
Orthodox Christianity	3,124	0.204	0.403	0	1
Not religious	3,124	0.192	0.394	0	1
Other	3,124	0.014	0.119	0	1
Muslim	3,124	0.589	0.492	0	1
Religious practice frequency ^a					
Never	2,524	0.135	0.342	0	1
At least once a year	2,524	0.189	0.392	0	1
At least once a month	2,524	0.216	0.411	0	1
At least once a week	2,524	0.293	0.455	0	1
Every day	2,524	0.166	0.373	0	1
Practices religion at least weekly	3,124	0.371	0.483	0	1
<i>Language and media</i>					
Language used at home					
Kazakh	3,124	0.517	0.500	0	1
Russian	3,124	0.477	0.500	0	1
Other	3,124	0.006	0.076	0	1
Language used with peers					
Kazakh	3,124	0.472	0.499	0	1
Russian	3,124	0.518	0.500	0	1
Other	3,124	0.010	0.099	0	1
Language used for news					
Kazakh	3,124	0.338	0.473	0	1
Russian	3,124	0.590	0.492	0	1
Other	3,124	0.006	0.078	0	1
Not interested in news	3,124	0.065	0.247	0	1
Russian media exposure (count)	3,124	0.71	1.12	0	4
Kazakh media exposure (count)	3,124	1.85	1.22	0	4
Western media exposure (count)	3,124	0.24	0.71	0	4

Other media exposure (count)	3,124	0.14	0.57	0	8
<i>Attitudes</i>					
General social trust (1–4)	3,124	2.40	0.71	1	4
Trust in government (1–4)	3,124	2.73	0.95	1	4
Gap perception: corruption (1–4)	3,124	3.31	0.82	1	4
Gap perception: Islamic fundamentalism (1–4)	3,124	2.72	0.93	1	4
Gap perception: security (1–4)	3,124	3.01	0.87	1	4
Gap perception: trust in society (1–4)	3,124	2.96	0.83	1	4
Gap perception: public health (1–4)	3,124	2.56	0.94	1	4

I Am Not an
Activist

Karpa &
Rochlitz

Category rows report the share of respondents in each category. Question wording and scales in Table 2. ^a Asked only of respondents who reported a religious affiliation ($N = 2,524$).

- **Experimental literature on citizen acceptance of algorithmic governance, and governance beyond the liberal-democratic frame:** we extend the experimental literature beyond the democratic settings in which it developed and provide the first experimental comparison of several promised outcomes as sources of approval in an autocracy. Previous studies focused on one outcome (Ingrams et al. 2022; Grimmelikhuijsen 2023; Hillo et al. 2025; Karini 2024; Knox & Orazgaliyev 2025; Gritsenko et al. 2025; Xu 2022)
- **Digital authoritarianism:** that literature models how the technology changes the calculus of preventive repression, diffuses across regimes and consolidates incumbent power. It studies what states do with the technology, whereas we ask why citizens accept it (Dragu & Lupu 2021; Beraja et al. 2023; Ruzza et al. 2026; Feldstein 2021)